

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CABO VERDE

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Cabo Verde is a stable, functioning Atlantic democracy with few natural resources beyond its climate and its extraordinary beauty, and it has staked its future on tourism — a choice that has brought real threats: sprawling resort development on islands like Sal and Boa Vista, much of it planned before any conservation plan and now overlapping the very protected areas meant to safeguard nature; and illegal sand mining that has stripped beaches bare, salinated farmland, and contaminated groundwater across several islands. Yet Cabo Verde also hosts one of the largest loggerhead turtle nesting populations in the world, and — thanks in large part to a genuinely effective conservation movement working with government and communities — the number of nests has been rising. There is no single landmark case of a community stopping a megaproject outright. But here, more than in most countries in this series, the levers genuinely work, and communities and their allies have real, demonstrable wins to build on.

A community in Cabo Verde facing a harmful project — a resort rising over a nesting beach, sand vanishing from a shore — works with a genuinely usable toolkit, in a democracy whose tools actually function. A major project must, in principle, undergo an **environmental impact assessment** — imperfect, but a real formal channel to engage. The **protected-area system of natural and marine reserves** — including the turtle reserves — carries legal protection a community can invoke against harmful development. The **courts** are open and functioning. A **free press and democratic accountability** let a community raise a matter and hold the deciders — the central government, the municipalities — to account; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And **deep European and international partnerships** add funding, standards, and scrutiny. Behind them all stands the distinctive Cabo Verdean lever: a **strong, effective conservation civil society** with a real track record — the movement that built the reserves and turned the tide for the turtles. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The tools work, but imperfectly: the assessment studies are not always robust, and the decision-making around them lacks transparency.

Tourism-development zones were drawn before conservation plans and now overlap protected areas, creating conflicts that favour development. And illegal sand mining, banned since the late 1990s, persists because authorities sometimes look away, and because for the impoverished women who do much of the harvesting it is a matter of survival — so the honest response is not only enforcement but alternative livelihoods, never mere punishment of the poor. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a project assessed, conditioned, or moved; a protected area defended; a beach and its turtles saved — in a democracy where, as the conservation movement has shown, the levers actually win ground.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here by combining a documented, legally grounded case with the strong conservation civil society and sustained public pressure, in a democracy that genuinely responds. Use the assessment to force the harm into the open, invoke the protected areas, turn to the courts and the press, and join the movement that has already shown these levers work — while answering the survival question behind illegal sand mining with alternatives, not only enforcement.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Cabo Verde is one of the more hopeful settings in this guide: a functioning democracy with a proven conservation movement. But honesty about the harder truths is the first discipline. The tools work imperfectly — assessments are not always robust, decisions lack transparency, and development-favouring zones overlap the reserves. And the sand mining that harms the beaches is, for many, a matter of survival, so the just response pairs enforcement with alternative livelihoods. So aim at the winnable — the project assessed, the reserve defended, the beach saved — using the levers the movement has already proven, and answering the poverty behind the harm.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Cabo Verdean development runs through several genuinely reachable tracks. The **central government and the municipalities** plan and approve development — the tourism zones, the permits — and are accountable, in a democracy, to the assessment, the courts, the press, and the voters. The **environmental ministry and the assessment process** must, in principle, evaluate major projects. The **protected-area system of natural and marine reserves** carries legal protections a community and the NGOs can invoke. And the **conservation civil society, the free press, and the international partners** are real forces. Map who decides a project's fate, at which level, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A major project should undergo an environmental assessment, and — on the coast or near a reserve — must reckon with the protected-area system. That assessment is your first entry point, imperfect though it is: the moment to document the harm, invoke the reserve, and press for conditions or refusal. Beyond it lie the courts, the protected-area protections, the press, and the conservation movement's pressure. Even a development-favouring process can be moved by a documented case and an organised public.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the permission: which government or municipality approves the project, on what assessment, and whether it overlaps a protected area. Follow the money: who is developing, and what European or international funding and standards apply. Follow the protection: which natural or marine reserve the project touches. The leverage lies in the assessment, the reserve designations, the courts, and the conservation movement.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Cabo Verde has real watchers: its environmental ministry and assessment process, its protected-area system, the courts, a free press, the strong conservation NGOs, and the European and international partners. These are the institutions a case is built to engage — and, where they fall short of their own standards, to hold to account.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition in Cabo Verde is genuinely achievable — the conservation movement has already built reserves and turned the tide for the turtles. The single most decisive move is **joining the strong conservation civil society and grounding the case in the protected areas and the assessment**, because Cabo Verde's institutions respond to a documented, legally-anchored case carried by a proven movement. The

assessment is the entry point; the reserves are the durable protection; the courts and press hold the deciders to account; the international partners add reach. What the tools deliver is a real, concrete result — a project assessed or conditioned, a reserve defended, a nesting beach saved — in a democracy where the levers actually win, and where the honest response to survival-driven harm pairs enforcement with alternatives.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the resort over a nesting beach, the sand stripped from a shore, the reserve overlapped. **What does it need?** — an environmental assessment, a permit, a clearance near a reserve. **Which protection does it touch?** — a natural or marine reserve, a turtle beach. **Who is the coalition?** — the conservation NGOs, the affected community, the press. **Is survival driving the harm?** — for sand mining especially, whether alternative livelihoods must be part of the answer. Pick the fight where the reserve or assessment offers the clearest handle and the movement is ready to join.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm** — the resort's footprint over the nesting beach, the sand mining's damage to the shore, farmland, and groundwater, the reserve overlapped. **Layer two: the protection and the process** — the reserve designation the project offends, the assessment it must satisfy and where it fell short, the law the sand mining breaks. **Layer three: the coalition and the livelihood** — the conservation NGOs to join, the courts or press to engage, and, for sand mining, the alternative livelihoods that must accompany enforcement. A case grounded in the reserve protections and the assessment — carried by the proven conservation movement — is one Cabo Verde's institutions take seriously.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the project's assessment and permit, the reserve boundaries it overlaps, the sand-mining damage to beach, farmland, and groundwater, the turtle-nesting data. Gather the **protection record**: the natural and marine reserve designations, the assessment requirements, the sand-mining ban. Gather the **coalition record**: the conservation NGOs, their track record, the affected community, the press. Gather the **livelihood record**: for sand mining, who harvests and why, and what alternatives exist. Cabo Verde's openness makes most of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Cabo Verde's distinctive strength is its conservation movement. Build the coalition around it: the **strong conservation NGOs** with their proven track record, the **affected community and its residents**, the **fishers and turtle-monitoring volunteers**, and the **free press**. Where illegal sand mining is the harm, build with the harvesters too, seeking alternative livelihoods rather than only enforcement, so the coalition answers the poverty that drives the damage. Join the movement that has already shown these levers work, and make the shared cause of nature and livelihood the ground of the coalition.

STEP 4: ASSESSMENT, PROTECTED-AREA & LEGAL LEVERS — THE PROCESS, THE RESERVES, AND THE COURTS

Set expectations honestly: here the levers are real and proven, in a functioning democracy, though they work imperfectly and development-favouring zones overlap the reserves.

The Environmental Assessment

A major project must, in principle, undergo an **environmental impact assessment**. Imperfect and imperfectly transparent though it is, it is a real formal channel: use the process to document the harm, invoke the reserve, and press for conditions, a corrected study, or refusal.

The Protected Areas

The **system of natural and marine reserves** — including the turtle reserves — carries legal protection a community and the NGOs can invoke against harmful development, as the movement has done. A reserve is a durable handle: a beach or habitat placed, in law, beyond a single project's reach.

The Courts, the Press, and the International Partners

Behind these stand the **courts and the free press**, which hold the deciders to account, and the **European and international partners**, who add funding, standards, and scrutiny. Pursued together — the assessment, the reserves, and the courts, carried by the conservation movement — these levers give a community a real chance to shape development and defend nature, as Cabo Verde has already shown.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the assessment authority**: here is the harm, the reserve it overlaps, and the corrected study or condition needed. **For the protected-area bodies and NGOs**: here is a reserve your protections cover, and here is the threat. **For the courts**: here is a project that breaches the reserve protections or the sand-mining ban. **For the press and public**: here is a nesting beach or a shore at stake, and a movement that has saved such places before. **For the international partners**: here is a project that strains the standards your funding carries. **The golden rule**: ground the case in the reserves and the assessment, carry it with the conservation movement, and — for survival-driven harm — pair enforcement with alternatives, so the fight wins nature and livelihood alike.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In a functioning democracy with a free press, media matters. Frame the story around **the beaches, the turtles, and the shared future**: a nesting beach or a shore at stake, and a proven movement determined to save it. Carry it through the national press, the international conservation outlets, and the movement's own networks. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the reserve protections and the science; never caricature the poor who mine sand to survive; and let the turtle data, the reserves, and the movement's track record carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the reserves and the assessment, and just toward the livelihoods in play.

8A — To the assessment authority: identify the project, the harm, and the reserve it overlaps, and request a corrected study, conditions, or refusal.

8B — To the protected-area bodies: connect the project to a natural or marine reserve and ask for the protection to be enforced.

8C — To a conservation NGO: share the case and ask the movement to join, drawing on its track record.

8D — To a municipality or the government: set out the harm and the reserve, and press for the protective decision.

8E — To the courts (through counsel): establish the breach of the reserve protections or the sand-mining ban.

8F — To a European or international partner: flag a project that strains the standards your funding carries.

8G — To the community (and sand harvesters): set out the shared stake and, for sand mining, the alternative livelihoods, and organise the coalition.

8H — To the press: offer the documented case, the turtle data, and the movement's record, and ask for coverage.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: find the project's assessment and permit and whether it overlaps a reserve; write the one-page case (the harm, the reserve, the process); reach the conservation NGOs. **The fastest-moving levers:** the assessment, the reserve protections, and the conservation movement. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the conservation NGOs, the affected community, and the press first; the movement mobilises quickly. Throughout, ground everything in the reserves and the assessment, and answer survival-driven harm with alternatives.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Even in a functioning democracy the field can tilt: development-favouring zones drawn over reserves, assessments that are not robust, decisions that lack transparency, authorities that look away from sand mining. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot reach — the reserve protections, the courts, the free press, the conservation movement, the international partners. In Cabo Verde these levers have already won ground. Accept, honestly, that the response to survival-driven harm must pair enforcement with alternatives, and that the tools, though real, work imperfectly.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — a permit granted against the science, a zone drawn to benefit a developer, authorities paid to look away. Where capture appears, respond through the open channels Cabo Verde genuinely provides: the courts, the assessment, the free press, the conservation movement, the international partners, and the transparency a democracy affords. **On safety:** Cabo Verde is a safe, rule-of-law democracy; the risks here are political and reputational, not physical, so the work is open, lawful, and public — but always accurate, and just toward the poor whose survival is bound up with the harm.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel. The documented harm feeds the assessment, the reserve claim, and the court-and-press case at once; the conservation movement and community organise alongside; the media carries the beaches-and-turtles frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the reserve, and engage the assessment and the NGOs; **months two to six**, press the reserve protections, the courts, the press, and the international partners, and build the coalition; **beyond**, secure the win and, for sand mining, the alternative livelihoods that make it last. The core discipline: grounded in the reserves and the assessment, carried by the proven movement, and just toward the poor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project in Cabo Verde is genuinely achievable — more so than in most places in this guide — because it is a stable, functioning democracy with a genuinely strong conservation movement, a protected-area system, an environmental-assessment process, open courts, a free press, and deep international partnerships. This guide has been honest that there is no single landmark case of stopping a megaproject outright, that the tools work imperfectly, that development-favouring zones overlap the reserves, and that the sand mining is, for many, a matter of survival. But those honest limits do not make the effort futile — the conservation movement has already built reserves and turned the tide for the turtles. A community that grounds its case in the reserves and the assessment, joins the proven movement, turns to the courts, the press, and the international partners, and answers survival-driven harm with alternatives can genuinely shape development, defend nature, and win ground — as Cabo Verde already has. The odds here are favourable, the tools are real, and the movement has shown the way.